

Jeanne Liedtka

The Evidence for Why Design Thinking Works

b. 1955 · United Technologies Professor of Business Administration · Darden, UVA



"Design thinking is a social technology."

"It works by counteracting the biases that undermine innovation."

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Design thinking is often sold on faith. Liedtka is the scholar who asked whether it actually works — and showed how, as a 'social technology' that manages the biases and politics of innovation. She is your bridge from method to measurable organisational outcome.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

American strategy scholar at UVA's Darden School. Her research studies design thinking empirically across dozens of organisations, explaining its effects through cognitive and organisational mechanisms rather than mystique.

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Design Thinking as social technology	Tools that reshape how people engage and decide
Bias-reduction mechanisms	How DT counters cognitive and organisational biases
The four-question method	What is · what if · what wows · what works
Design thinking for the public sector	Applying DT to government and social problems
Innovation as learning	Reframing uncertainty as experimentation

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Treat DT tools as guards against specific biases
- Structure innovation as what-is / what-if / what-wows / what-works
- Use customer data to align stakeholders and reduce ego
- Prototype to convert conflict into shared learning
- Measure DT by outcomes, not activity

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Effects mediated by culture and leadership, not automatic
- Empirical base still developing
- Hard to isolate DT's contribution from other factors
- Requires sustained commitment to show results
- Public-sector applications face structural constraints

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- 'Why Design Thinking Works' a landmark HBR article
- Brought empirical rigour to a practitioner field
- Widely taught framework for evaluating innovation methods
- Extended DT credibly into the public sector
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Units 3 and 10

SELECTED WORKS

DESIGNING FOR GROWTH

A Design Thinking Tool Kit for Managers

LIEDTKA & OGILVIE · 2011

WHY DESIGN THINKING WORKS

Harvard Business Review

LIEDTKA · 2018

SOLVING PROBLEMS WITH DESIGN THINKING

Ten Stories

LIEDTKA · 2013

DESIGN THINKING FOR THE GREATER GOOD

Columbia Business School

LIEDTKA · 2017

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Liedtka, J. (2018) 'Why Design Thinking Works', *Harvard Business Review*, 96(5), pp. 72–79.

Liedtka, J. and Ogilvie, T. (2011) *Designing for Growth*. New York: Columbia Business School Publishing.